

Variscite

△ **Sawn variscite** nodule showing its internal pattern

Found as **fine-grained masses**, in veins, crusts, or in nodules, and occasionally as crystals, variscite is valued as a semiprecious gemstone for cabochons, carvings, and as an ornamental material. Black webbing sometimes occurs in the matrix of the variscite local to Nevada, USA, and this form of the mineral is often confused with green turquoise; cabochons originating in Nevada that look like turquoise but are in fact variscite may be sold as “variquoise”. Variscite is porous and can discolour if worn next to the skin.

Specification

Chemical name Aluminium phosphate | **Formula** $\text{AlPO}_4 \cdot 2\text{H}_2\text{O}$
Colours Pale to apple-green | **Structure** Orthorhombic
Hardness 3.5–4.5 | **SG** 2.5–2.6 | **RI** 1.55–1.59 | **Lustre**
 Vitreous to waxy | **Streak** White | **Locations** Austria, Czech Republic, Australia, Venezuela, USA, especially Utah



Crystalline variscite | Rough | In this specimen, a crust of crystalline variscite has formed on top of a large piece of massive (lacking a definite shape) variscite.

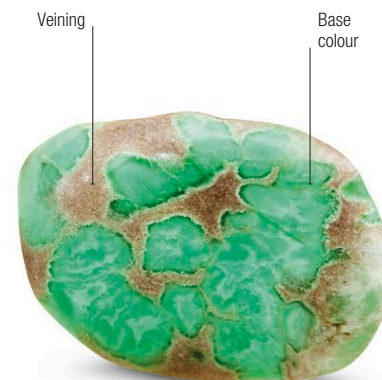
Massive form

Crystalline form



Polished end

Raw gem | Rough | An end of this piece of variscite gem rough has been polished to reveal its colour and solidity. It has a waxy, semi-matte lustre.



Veining

Base colour

Tumbled variscite | Cut | Variscite unsuitable for cabochons is often tumble-polished to disclose interesting swirls and patterns, and sold for ornamental use.

Variscite is named for Variscia, the old name for the German district of Voightland, where it was first discovered in 1837



High dome

Oval cabochon | Cut | Variscite with a consistent colour and density can be cut into attractive cabochons like this one, which has been polished to reveal its vitreous lustre.